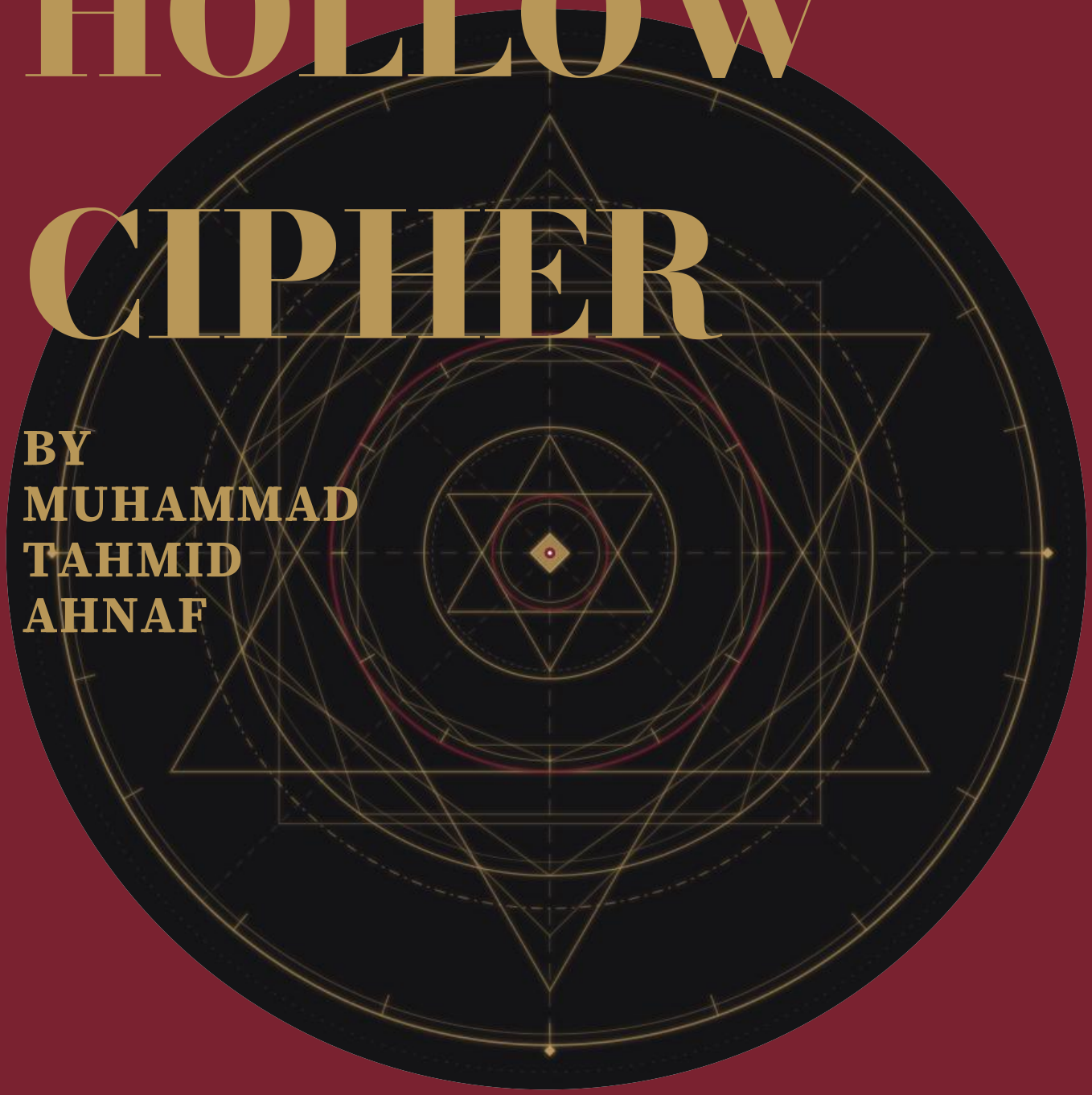
THE HOLLOW CIPHER



BY
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LEVEL 5

THE HOLLOW CIPHER

[Level 5; Case: The Hollow Cipher]

[Time] 2nd December, 1887 | 11:47 PM

[Location] The Palassy Grounds, Dhaka

[Statement]

At midnight, Dhaka began to bleed.

It started in the old quarter, where a watchman fell dead beside a locked gate, his mouth filled with black water. Before anyone could summon a physician, three more bodies were discovered in neighbouring streets. A woman collapsed while praying before an unlit shrine. A magistrate was found sitting upright at his dining table, every mirror in his house turned toward the wall. At the riverbank, a boat drifted ashore carrying seven passengers who had drowned without a drop of water in their lungs.

Then the bells began to ring.

Not from a single temple, mosque, church, or clock tower, but from everywhere at once. Some bells had no ropes. Others hung in buildings that had been abandoned for decades. The great clock above the newspaper district struck thirteen, stopped, and began counting backward.

The full moon rose above Dhaka, swollen and red as an open wound. Its light washed over rooftops, flooded narrow alleys, and turned every puddle into a black mirror. People crowded into their homes and barred their doors. Those who looked through their windows saw figures standing in the streets, perfectly still, their faces turned toward the moon. Those who looked again found the streets empty.

Then the screaming began.

Blood seeped between the stones of the roads. It gathered in the gutters and flowed downhill, although the streets were dry and the dead had no visible wounds. It passed beneath doors, climbed the steps of locked houses, and gathered around the foundations of the old newspaper archive. Dogs fled the city. Horses tore free of their harnesses. Somewhere beyond the rooftops, wolves howled, although no one in Dhaka could remember the last time a wolf had been seen within a hundred miles.

And from every corner of the city came the same whisper.

The Eye has opened.

The investigator stood at the archive window, watching the blood flow through the streets, and understood that Mahir Hossain had not been bluffing. The Evil Eye's Wrath had begun its final operation. The network that had once relied on rumours, staged miracles, and carefully arranged deaths had become something no longer confined to its members. Its symbols appeared on doors whose owners had never heard of the cult. Strangers spoke the same words in languages they had never learned. Men who had never met Arif Rahman awoke with his name written beneath their fingernails.

Across Bengal, reports arrived faster than they could be read. Deaths without injuries. Children describing rooms they had never entered. Families hearing familiar voices from sealed wells. Entire households found kneeling before blank walls. The cult had become a nationwide phenomenon, and its members were no longer the only people participating in it.

The investigator returned to the hidden chamber beneath the eastern wing. Mahir was gone. The national ledger lay open, its pages fluttering although the air was still. Every name had been crossed out except one: the investigator's.

Beneath it was a final instruction.

WHEN THE LAST WITNESS REMEMBERS, THE FIRST SIN WILL BE COMPLETE.

The notebook recovered from Jawer remained on the table. Its pages had always appeared blank, but under the blood moon, the impressions within them had become visible. Lines connected the deaths, the photographs, the anonymous message, the curses, and the impossible records. The notebook did not contain a confession. It contained the architecture of the entire nightmare.

Arif had discovered the first layer. Jawer had stolen the second. Mahir had concealed the third. The investigator had assembled the rest.

Yet the final page contained no name, no location, and no instruction that could be followed.

It contained an empty space.

The investigator placed the pendant beside it. The crossed out eye seemed to disappear into the darkness of the page. For the first time, the notebook's title became visible beneath the impressions, as though the words had been waiting for the light of the blood moon.

THE HOLLOW CIPHER.

Arif's surviving notebooks had been analysed by the investigator and the remaining members of the newspaper staff. The final clues had emerged only after a desperate search through his notes, during which a collapsing passage nearly buried the investigator alive. The surviving pages revealed how the cult's symbols connected its local cells, how its members used staged incidents to create belief, and how the curses attached

to Arif, Arindom, and Jawer had followed their attempts to conceal, escape, or possess the secret.

But the notebooks stopped just before the final answer.

They revealed the mechanism by which the cult spread. They exposed the people who had carried out its work. They explained how Mahir had manipulated the investigation and used truth itself as a means of control.

They did not reveal how to stop it.

Every page pointed toward the same conclusion, then withdrew from it. The symbols could be translated, but the translation produced another set of symbols. The dates could be ordered, but every possible sequence led back to the night Arif died. The names could be removed from the ledger, but they reappeared in the notebook's impressions.

The cult could not be defeated by killing its leaders. Mahir had already disappeared. Its local cells had begun operating independently. Arresting its followers would only create more martyrs. Destroying the documents would leave the stories intact. Exposing the truth would spread the symbols to people who had never encountered them.

There was only one thing left to find.

The final key.

At three minutes before midnight, the archive's doors slammed shut. Every lantern extinguished at once. The investigator heard footsteps moving through the corridors, accompanied by the sound of a camera being wound.

A voice spoke from the darkness.

“You have spent five cases learning what happened.”

A shutter clicked.

“Now you must decide whether it should have happened at all.”

The lanterns returned.

Mahir stood at the opposite end of the chamber, holding no camera. His clothes were soaked in blood, yet there was no wound on his body. Behind him, the wall was covered with photographs of the investigator at every stage of the investigation.

Some showed the investigator entering rooms that had not yet been discovered. Others showed the investigator reading documents that had not yet been written. One showed the investigator standing beside Arif's body on 5 October 1887.

The investigator had never seen that scene.

Mahir raised his empty hands.

“The cult is already beyond my command,” he said. **“I wanted to make the nation believe in the Eye. I never promised that I could control what answered.”**

Outside, something enormous struck the archive's foundations.

Dust fell from the ceiling. The blood moon filled the window.

Mahir looked at the notebook.

“You have the names. You have the history. You have the truth. But the truth is precisely what keeps it alive.”

The investigator looked down at the empty space on the final page.

For the first time, the meaning of the title became clear.

The cipher was not hiding a word.

It was hiding the absence of one.

[Question]

What is it?

[Evidences]

[Arif's Final Notebooks]

The surviving notebooks of Arif Rahman contain his most complete investigation into the Evil Eye's Wrath. Their early pages document the disappearances and unexplained incidents that first drew his attention. Later pages identify the intermediaries, coded communications, and staged events used to expand the cult's influence.

The final notebooks reveal that the cult's power depends on a chain of recognition. An event is witnessed, interpreted, recorded, and repeated. A symbol becomes associated with a death. A death becomes evidence of a curse. The curse becomes a story. The story becomes a reason to obey the people who claim to understand it.

Arif discovered that the chain could survive the death of any individual involved. A witness could be silenced, a document destroyed, or a leader imprisoned, yet the story would continue through those who remembered it. The cult did not require every follower to understand its purpose. It needed only enough people to preserve its meaning.

On the last complete page, Arif wrote:

If the Eye is a story, destroy the story.

The next page contains a correction in different ink.

No. A destroyed story becomes a legend. A legend is a story that has survived its witnesses.

The remaining pages are blank. Their impressions are visible only when placed beneath the notebook recovered from Jawer. Together, the two sets of marks form a sequence that cannot be read as ordinary writing.

A final note appears in the binding, written in Arif's hand:

DO NOT ERASE THE EYE. ERASE THE DISTINCTION BETWEEN THE EYE AND THE WORLD THAT GAVE IT A NAME.

[The Blood Ledger]

The national ledger records the cult's expansion across Bengal. Its entries establish that the incidents were coordinated, that Mahir used his photographic work to support the operation, and that local followers were instructed to create events that appeared to confirm the Eye's power.

The ledger also contains a second system of notation. Beside each completed operation is a small mark resembling a closed circle. Beside each event that has not yet occurred is an open one. The investigator initially assumes that the marks distinguish success from failure.

Under closer examination, the distinction is stranger. Some closed circles appear beside events that have not happened. Some open circles appear beside deaths that have already been recorded. A few entries contain both marks, written in the same hand.

The final pages describe a sequence called the Convergence. It requires the simultaneous presence of every name, every symbol, and every witness associated with the cult's origin. The ledger calls this the point at which the network becomes self sustaining.

At the bottom of the final page is a diagram of a circle with no centre.

The instructions beside it are brief:

When every part has found its place, remove the place that makes them parts.

[The Crossed Eye Pendant]

The rhombus pendant recovered from Jawer bears the crossed out eye. Its metal contains traces of the same unusual mineral residue found in the mortar beneath the eastern wing of the archive.

The pendant was originally treated as an emblem of membership. The final notebooks reveal a second function. The crossed eye represents a failed attempt to separate observation from consequence. The rhombus represents the boundaries within which the cult's symbols can be recognised and repeated.

The pendant's reverse contains a shallow groove that matches the shape of the empty space in the notebook. When placed against the final page, the groove aligns with the

page's impressions, completing a pattern that resembles neither a map nor a written alphabet.

The investigator turns the pendant over.

For an instant, the crossed out eye appears intact.

Then the metal becomes cold, and the symbol vanishes.

[The Photograph That Has No Negative]

The unlisted photographic plate from Mahir's archive shows the hidden chamber, the national ledger, and the investigator standing beside the empty chair. It is the same impossible photograph discovered in the previous case, but the image has changed.

The chair is no longer empty.

Arif Rahman sits in it, his face pale, his clothing stained with blood. He is looking directly at the camera. Behind him stands Arindom, his eyes closed. Jawer stands beside the wall, holding the notebook. Mahir is nowhere in the image.

The investigator examines the plate under magnification. There is no visible negative image, no normal layer of photographic emulsion, and no evidence that the image was produced by the apparatus in Mahir's studio.

On the reverse is a sentence that was not present before:

THE PHOTOGRAPHER CAN SHOW YOU WHAT WAS THERE. THE CIPHER CAN REMOVE THE NEED FOR IT TO HAVE BEEN THERE AT ALL.

The plate then begins to darken from its edges inward. The figures disappear one by one. Arif is the last to vanish.

For a fraction of a second, the investigator sees the empty chair.

It has the same shape as the chair in the investigator's own room.

[The Three Dates]

The investigator compares the dates recorded in Arif's notebooks, the national ledger, and the blank notebook recovered from Jawer.

The first date is 5 October 1887, the day Arif died. The second belongs to Arindom's death in custody. The third is 14 October 1887, the date on which the investigator's handwriting records the killing of Jawer.

The three dates are connected by the same symbol, but the order of the marks differs in each document. In one, the dates run forward. In another, they run backward. In the third, the dates are arranged in a circle.

The investigator initially believes that the documents describe a sequence of events. The notebooks suggest otherwise. The dates identify three moments at which the cult's history became fixed in the minds of its participants.

Arif knew the truth and tried to expose it.

Arindom knew enough to conceal it and tried to escape its consequences.

Jawer wanted to possess it and became trapped by the secret.

The investigator has done something different. The investigator has connected the events, given them a single explanation, and preserved them in a casebook.

In the margin, someone has written:

THE LAST WITNESS IS NOT THE LAST PERSON TO SEE. IT IS THE LAST PERSON TO MAKE THE EVENTS MEAN THE SAME THING.

The ink is fresh.

[The Empty Page]

The final page of the notebook contains no visible writing. It has no impressions, no watermarks, no concealed symbols, and no marks that can be revealed by heat or light.

Every previous page can be connected to a name, a date, a location, or an event. The final page has no such connection.

The investigator compares it with the other pages and discovers that its edges are perfectly aligned, although the notebook has been damaged and distorted by moisture. The paper contains no fibres from the surrounding pages. Under the lens, its surface appears to recede beyond the physical depth of the sheet.

The page is not a missing piece of the cipher.

It is the only part that has never been written.

Arif's final note refers to it as the hollow. The national ledger calls it the point of convergence. Mahir's private register calls it the reset.

The investigator places the page beneath the blood moon's light.

Nothing happens.

Then every sound in the chamber stops.

The lantern flame freezes. The dust hangs in the air. The blood outside the window becomes motionless. Even the investigator's breathing seems to have ceased.

For one impossible moment, the world has no next moment.

When movement returns, the page remains blank.

A sentence appears in the investigator's casebook, not on the page itself:

THE CIPHER DOES NOT TELL YOU WHAT TO WRITE. IT TELLS YOU WHAT MUST NO LONGER BE WRITTEN.

[The Last Instruction]

A hidden compartment opens in the underside of the chamber table when the pendant is placed beside the empty page. Inside lies a small sheet of paper bearing a final note in Arif's handwriting.

The note is not a translation key. It contains no alphabet, no substitution table, and no instructions for decoding symbols. It is a warning about the nature of the final act.

The cult has made a world in which every death proves the Eye, every witness confirms the story, and every attempt to expose it gives it another name.

You cannot destroy it by killing the people who believe in it. Their deaths will become its scripture.

You cannot destroy it by revealing the truth. The truth will become its testimony.

You cannot destroy it by making the world forget. Forgetting leaves a space where the story can return.

The only escape is a state in which there is no distinction between the story and its absence. No witness to confirm it. No record to preserve it. No name to summon it.

The Hollow Cipher is not the answer to the Eye.

It is the answer to the question that allows the Eye to exist.

The final line is written so faintly that the investigator must hold the paper against the lantern to read it.

If you complete it, do not expect to remember why you did.

[Interrogation]

[Mahir Hossain]

Mahir sits on the floor of the chamber, his back against the wall. The blood moon shines through the narrow window behind him. He no longer looks like the composed photographer who manipulated the investigation. His hands tremble. His eyes move constantly toward the empty chair.

Investigator: The cult has begun. The deaths are spreading beyond your network. You said you gave it a shape. What have you actually awakened?

Mahir: I thought the Eye was an idea. A name that people would fear, a symbol they would recognise, a story they would repeat. I thought that if enough people believed in it, the belief would become power.

Investigator: And now?

Mahir: Now I think I confused the door with the thing behind it.

Investigator: Did you know this would happen?

Mahir: I knew what I intended to happen. That is not the same as knowing what would happen.

Investigator: You sent the anonymous message. You led me to the chamber. You made me connect the evidence.

Mahir: Yes.

Investigator: Why?

Mahir: Because I could not complete the cipher.

Investigator: You orchestrated the entire conspiracy, but you could not finish your own plan?

Mahir: The cult was never the final purpose. It was the instrument. I needed a person who could see the entire structure without belonging to any of its original covenants. Someone who would investigate the deaths, recover the notebook, enter the chamber, and understand what the cult had done.

Investigator: You needed me to solve it.

Mahir: I needed you to become the final witness.

Investigator: You could have told me the truth.

Mahir: Would you have believed me? If I had told you that the only way to stop a conspiracy was to remove every fact that made it possible, would you have helped me? Or would you have arrested me and published the confession?

Mahir looks at the notebook.

Mahir: You needed to discover the truth for yourself. You needed to believe that the answer belonged to you. That was the last part I could not manufacture.

Investigator: The final page is blank.

Mahir: Because there is nothing left to add.

Investigator: Then what do I do?

Mahir closes his eyes.

Mahir: You must stop trying to solve it.

Investigator: That is your answer?

Mahir: It is the only answer I could never make myself accept.

A distant bell rings thirteen times.

Mahir begins to cry.

Mahir: I wanted to be the man who could control what people believed. I wanted every photograph to become evidence, every death to become a message, every fear to become an instrument. I believed that if I could control the story, I could control what came after it.

He looks up at the investigator.

Mahir: But I never understood why the last page was blank.

Investigator: Tell me.

Mahir: Because I kept trying to write myself into it.

Mahir reaches toward the pendant. Before his fingers touch it, the skin of his hand becomes transparent beneath the lantern light. The bones remain visible for a moment, then fade.

He screams and pulls away.

Mahir: It has started.

Investigator: What has?

Mahir: The removal.

The investigator steps back. Mahir's face is becoming difficult to focus on, not because it is disappearing, but because every time the investigator looks away and looks back, a different detail has changed. His eyes are brown, then grey, then black. His mouth moves, but the sound arrives a moment later.

Mahir: Do not let it make you the author.

Investigator: How do I stop that?

Mahir looks at the blank page.

Mahir: Leave nothing for it to remember.

His final words are almost inaudible.

Mahir: And if you hear me again, do not answer.

Mahir disappears.

His clothes fall to the floor without a sound.

The investigator searches the chamber. There is no blood, no body, and no evidence that anyone was sitting against the wall. Only the national ledger remains open, its final page empty.

[The Final Convergence]

The investigator places Arif's notebooks beside the ledger. The pendant rests between them. The blank notebook lies open before the empty chair.

Every symbol in the room begins to move.

The marks on the ledger shift into new positions. The lines on the maps detach from their locations. The photographs curl inward, their images withdrawing into the glass. Names disappear from the pages, leaving impressions that fade as the paper returns to its original state.

Outside, the blood flowing through the streets rises from the gutters. It climbs the walls, crosses the windows, and hangs in the air as a thousand suspended droplets. Each droplet contains a tiny reflection of the blood moon.

The howling stops.

The bells fall silent.

For the first time since the cult began, there is no sound from the city.

The investigator opens the blank notebook to its final page.

Nothing appears.

A thought comes, clear and terrible: perhaps the cipher requires a sacrifice. Perhaps a name must be written. Perhaps the investigator must die, or Mahir must be found, or the notebook must be burned. Every possibility arrives with the certainty of a discovered truth.

Then the investigator recognises the trick.

Every proposed solution preserves the structure of the problem. A sacrifice requires a victim. A name requires someone to bear it. A death creates a witness. A burning leaves ashes. Even destroying the notebook would turn the act of destruction into another event that could be remembered, described, and repeated.

The cult had built a world in which every action became evidence of its own importance.

The Hollow Cipher required an action that would not become another part of the story.

The investigator looks at the empty page and finally understands why the notebook cannot be decoded in the ordinary sense. The cipher does not translate the cult's symbols into a hidden command. It removes the relationships that allow the symbols to function. It does not answer the question of what the Eye means. It removes the distinction that makes the Eye mean anything at all.

The investigator takes up the pen.

For a moment, the temptation is overwhelming. One word would make the solution tangible. One sentence would turn the discovery into something that could be recorded. One signature would prove that the investigator had been the person who completed the work.

But Mahir's warning returns.

Do not let it make you the author.

The investigator puts down the pen.

The final key is not a word to be written on the page. It is the refusal to supply the page with another word.

The Hollow Cipher is complete.

The room does not explode. No great light fills the chamber. There is no voice announcing the defeat of the Evil Eye. The lantern simply goes out.

The darkness is absolute.

Then the investigator hears Arif's voice.

“Do you understand now?”

The investigator cannot see anything.

“The Eye needed someone to witness it.”

A second voice answers. Arindom's.

“The covenant needed someone to remember it.”

Then Jawer speaks.

“And the secret needed someone to possess it.”

The investigator wants to answer, but no words come.

Arif speaks once more.

“Then let it have nothing.”

Something moves in the darkness. The investigator feels the presence of countless people standing in the chamber, their faces close, their breaths cold against the skin. There are children, old men, strangers, and the dead. Every person who has ever heard the name of the Evil Eye's Wrath seems to be waiting for the investigator to acknowledge them.

At the centre of the darkness, a single eye opens.

It is not a human eye. It has no iris, no pupil, and no lid. It is a hole through which the investigator can see the same chamber, the same notebook, and the same empty chair. Beyond that chamber is another, and beyond that another, each containing the same objects and the same figure standing before them.

The eye is not looking at the investigator.

It is looking for the moment when the investigator will recognise it.

The investigator closes their own eyes.

The eye remains visible.

The investigator forgets the room.

The room remains.

The investigator forgets the notebook.

The notebook remains.

Then the investigator stops trying to forget.

For one immeasurable instant, there is no difference between remembering and forgetting, between the witness and the witnessed, between the symbol and the thing it represents.

There is no Eye.

There is no cult.

There is no story about the cult.

There is no person who can testify that the cult ever existed.

The world falls silent.

[Past History]

[Arif Rahman]

Arif Rahman was the journalist whose investigation first exposed the connection between the unexplained incidents and the Evil Eye's Wrath. His death on 5 October 1887 was arranged to conceal the evidence he had gathered. The notebook he pursued contained the structure of the cult's network, but his final discovery went beyond identifying its members. He realised that the cult's power depended on the continuation of its story through witnesses, records, and repeated acts of belief.

His unfinished work became the foundation of the Hollow Cipher. Arif did not leave a conventional key because the final operation could not be completed by adding another piece of information. It required the removal of the relationships that allowed the information to preserve the cult.

[Arindom Kumar Biswas]

Arindom participated in the concealment of Arif's investigation and believed that cooperation would protect him. His death in custody followed his attempt to escape the consequences of the covenant he had accepted. His fate demonstrated that concealment could not sever a person from the system they had helped sustain.

His name became part of the cult's history, and his death became another story through which the Eye could be invoked.

[Jawer Chakrovarty]

Jawer stole the notebook because he believed that possession of the cult's secret would give him power over its members. Instead, the theft made him part of the chain that preserved the secret. The notebook's apparent emptiness concealed the relationships between the people, places, and events connected to the cult.

The investigator's unexplained statement that Jawer was killed on 14 October 1887 remained unresolved. The final convergence did not produce a body or establish how the statement had been written. It removed the system of meaning that had allowed the claim to function as evidence.

[Mahir Hossain]

Mahir Hossain orchestrated the human conspiracy behind the Evil Eye's Wrath. He manipulated evidence, staged incidents, sent the anonymous message, and guided the investigator through the previous cases. He believed that control over the story would give him control over the consequences.

His ambition helped transform a secretive network into a nationwide cult. Yet the events in the hidden chamber revealed the limits of his power. Mahir could manipulate what people saw and how they interpreted it, but he could not fully command the phenomenon his organisation had invoked.

His final disappearance was not independently explained. The investigator found neither his body nor any reliable evidence of his escape.

[The Evil Eye's Wrath]

The Evil Eye's Wrath used staged miracles, unexplained deaths, blackmail, and carefully circulated rumours to expand its influence across Bengal. Its leaders encouraged people to interpret fear as proof of supernatural authority and to depend on the cult for protection from the threats it helped create.

The network became self sustaining because its stories survived the individuals who first told them. Every death could be used as a warning. Every witness could become a recruiter. Every attempt to expose the conspiracy could spread its symbols to a wider audience.

The Hollow Cipher ended that continuity. Rather than destroying the cult's leaders or its documents, it removed the relationships that allowed its identity to persist. The final

convergence returned the system to nothingness, preventing the cult from being remembered as a coherent entity that could be worshipped, feared, or rebuilt.

[Solution]

The Hollow Cipher

[Explanation]

The Hollow Cipher is the final key to stopping the Evil Eye's Wrath because it does not defeat the cult through violence, exposure, or conventional destruction. It removes the foundation on which the cult exists.

Throughout the five levels, each attempt to understand the conspiracy produces more evidence. Arif's investigation exposes the first crimes. The search for the notebook reveals Jawer's involvement. The hidden chamber uncovers the national network. Mahir's confession identifies the mastermind. Yet every discovery also strengthens the story connecting the Eye to the world. Each witness preserves the cult by giving its events a shared meaning.

Mahir understood how to manipulate this process, but he did not understand its final consequence. He could arrange what people saw, lead them toward conclusions, and turn their fear into a tool. He could not control what answered when the cult's manufactured mythology became a self sustaining reality.

The Hollow Cipher breaks that chain. Its empty page represents the absence of a final witness, a definitive record, or a stable identity through which the cult can continue. The reset does not simply erase the cult's name. It removes the conditions that allow the name to refer to something that can be remembered and recreated.

The blood moon vanishes. The blood drains from the streets. The unexplained deaths cease. The bells stop ringing. Across Bengal, the people who had been drawn into the cult's operations return to their ordinary lives, with no coherent memory of the organisation that had begun to consume them. The photographs are blank. The ledger contains no names. The notebook is nothing more than a worn book with empty pages.

The investigator wakes at a desk in the newspaper archive.

Morning light enters through the window. The city beyond it is alive with ordinary sounds. Vendors call from the street. Carriages rattle over the stones. Somewhere, a child laughs.

The investigator looks at the calendar.

15 October 1887.

There is no record of the blood moon. No reports of the deaths. No evidence of the nationwide cult. Arif Rahman is alive in the newspaper's records, his investigation still unfinished. Arindom remains a respected editor. Jawer has no recorded connection to any secret organisation. Mahir's name appears in a routine list of photographers who supplied images to the paper.

The investigator searches the desk for the casebook.

It is there, but every page is blank.

For the first time, the investigator feels no urge to fill it.

The game ends with the archive's front door opening. A stranger enters, carrying a small parcel wrapped in brown paper. They ask whether the newspaper accepts private correspondence.

The investigator says yes.

The stranger places the parcel on the desk and leaves without giving a name.

Inside is a photographic plate.

It shows the investigator seated at the desk, looking directly toward the viewer. The image is dated 14 October 1887. In the background stands a man holding a camera.

The investigator turns the plate over.

There is no writing.

No symbol.

No name.

Only a faint impression in the glass, as though someone had once pressed a pen against it. The investigator holds the plate toward the morning light. For a fraction of a second, a sentence appears:

THE FIRST WITNESS WAS NEVER ARIF.

Then the glass becomes clear. The investigator places it in the drawer and closes it. The drawer clicks shut. From somewhere deep within the archive comes the sound of a camera shutter.

The investigator does not turn around.

And in the silence, one final question remains unanswered: if The Hollow Cipher erased every trace of the cult, who preserved the photograph that proved it had once existed?